

Two Tablespoons and a Blanket: Fermenting Yogurt Without a Thermometer

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In a Turkish kitchen, yogurt isn't started from a packet of freeze-dried culture, you keep it going, or start it fresh from any live yogurt already in your fridge. My family calls the spoonful saved to start the next batch the *mayalık*, but that culture doesn't have to trace back to another *mayalık* at all: I used a tablespoon from an ordinary tub of plain, unflavored grocery-store yogurt, and it fermented the next batch exactly the same way.

The process itself is almost insultingly simple. I brought a liter of whole cow's milk (*Bos taurus*) just to the point of foaming, then let it cool until I could hold a clean pinky finger in it through a slow count of ten, about 45°C. I whisked the tablespoon of store-bought yogurt with a ladleful of the warm milk in a separate bowl, folded that back into the pot, sealed it, wrapped the whole thing in a wool blanket, and left it in the turned-off oven overnight, undisturbed, for about seven hours.

The change by morning was more dramatic than I expected. The milk had gone from a thin liquid to a single wobbling mass that pulled cleanly away from the side of the pot when tilted, with a thin layer of whey on top and a faint sour smell that hadn't been there before. Nothing about the texture resembled curdling; it was one continuous, custard-like gel, not clumps floating in liquid. That distinction is the whole point: scalding the milk denatures its proteins so the fermenting bacteria, *Lactobacillus delbrueckii* and *Streptococcus thermophilus*, the two species named in our fermentation reading, can reach the nutrients they need, and as they

convert lactose into lactic acid overnight, the dropping pH bonds those loosened proteins into the solid network I found that morning.

I found the process easy and nerve-racking in almost equal measure. Easy, because it asks for only two ingredients and no equipment beyond a pot and a blanket; nerve-racking, because all of the actual difficulty is compressed into a temperature window I was trusting my finger, not a thermometer, to judge. Too hot, and the bacteria die before they establish themselves; too cool, and they work too slowly to set the milk overnight, or slower-growing competitors get there first. There is no written recipe for this part, just the finger test, taught by watching, which made it feel less like cooking than like repeating an inherited motion correctly.

That's really the surprising part. The bacteria don't care whether their tablespoon came from a grocery-store shelf or a jar kept going for decades, a live culture is a live culture, and once it has fermented a fresh batch, that batch becomes just as valid a starter as the tub it came from. Making the yogurt took one evening; realizing I could keep the process going indefinitely, from a single spoonful, without ever buying starter again, took a little longer.